

COLD CALLS

What one call looks like, side to side

OFFICE OF SOCIAL CLIMATE
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Two strangers pick up handsets on opposite sides of an easel. Either side can be the caller – whoever lifts first becomes Side A for that call. The roles are not fixed to a physical side.

SIDE A the caller		SIDE B the receiver
BEFORE THE CALL		
idle	on hook, silent	on hook, silent
SOMEONE PICKS UP		
0:00	LIFTS THE HANDSET hears: dial tone	on hook hears: nothing
0:02	dial tone cuts off hears: touch-tone dialing dials a random famous number – Jenny's 867-5309, and friends	hears: nothing
RINGING		
0:04	hears: ringback, twice brrr-brrr ... brrr-brrr two cadences, 12 seconds	>>> THE PRINTER BUZZES one buzz every 2 seconds The handset does not ring. The receipt printer is the bell – it is what recruits a stranger who has not opted in yet.
ON HOLD		
0:16	ringback ends, hears: "This call requires another participant to continue holding the line..." over hold music, recurring every 20 seconds – one minute of it, fading out at the end	printer still buzzing, unanswered
up to 1:16	hold music stops	LIFTS THE HANDSET
BOTH HANDSETS UP		
+0s	hears: "Both participants are now present."	hears: dial tone, then touch-tone dialing
Side B hears its own dial tone and dialing on pickup, mirroring what the caller heard when they first lifted the handset – both people got to make a call. Side A's line runs at the same time and is timed to roughly the same length.		
THE HEADS-UP		
+4s	hears: "Printing your questionnaire now."	hears, the same moment: "Printing your questionnaire now."
THE PRINT		
+6s	the receipt prints a prompt from this side's department	the receipt prints a different prompt, from the other department
Both printers run with nothing else on the bus – the phones and the printers share one USB controller, so audio never overlaps a print. It is fast and loud on purpose: the machine chattering out a foot of paper is the event, not a wait to be filled.		
THE BRIEFING		

+18s hears:
"Greetings from the Seattle Municipal Office of Social Climate. You've been contracted by one of our sub-agencies to investigate a particular aspect of the social phenomenon known as the Seattle Freeze. You will soon be connected to a fellow investigator and given a printed questionnaire. Read the question aloud to them, then document their response on your questionnaire using the writing instruments provided, before posting your form to the board with an adhesive seal."

hears, the same moment:
(the same line)

The briefing runs after the print, not before it, so the paper is already in their hands while the voice explains what to do with it. About 28 seconds. This is the only thing that teaches the conceit – the receipt carries its procedure, but nobody reads a form they have not been told to care about.

THE OPERATOR

+46s hears:
"One moment please, your call is being connected."

hears, the same moment:
"One moment please, your call is being connected."

CONNECTED

+50s voice ----->
 <----- earpiece
 rain / city ambience mixed softly underneath

<----- earpiece
 voice ----->
 rain / city ambience mixed softly underneath

They talk. They read each other their prompts. They answer with stamps, stickers, and tape on the easel between them – no pens. It runs as long as they both stay on the handset. There is no time limit.

EITHER SIDE HANGS UP

— **HANGS UP**
 or the other side does – it works the same either way

still holding the handset
 hears: a click, then a busy tone, looping until they hang up too

+1s both on hook – ready for the next pair

both on hook – ready for the next pair

IF NOBODY ANSWERS

0:04 hears: ringback, twice (12s)

printer buzzing, unanswered

0:16 hold music, one minute, message every 20 seconds
 fades out over the last 4 seconds – the wait audibly ends before the intercept says so

printer buzzing, unanswered

1:16 hears:
"We're sorry. The number you have dialed is not in service. Please hang up and try again."

still on hook

1:22 click, then busy tone until they hang up

—

All of this is implemented in `src/cold_call/session.py` and has been run on the hardware. Times before the receiver answers are exact. The +Ns marks after it are clip lengths plus an assumed 12s print – the print takes as long as it takes, so everything after it shifts with it. Conversation length is unbounded.